THE DARK SIDE

Director Bejoy Nambiar is back with *Kaala*, a richly layered series that is so much more than an action thriller



TWISTED TALES
A still from *Kaala* and (bottom) Bejoy Nambiar

By now, filmmaker Bejoy Nambiar is all too familiar with what clicks and doesn't on streaming platforms. He has made a short for an anthology (Netflix's *Navarasa*), co-directed two series (*The Fame Game*, *Sweet Kaaram Coffee*) and had one direct-to-digital film release (*Taish* on ZEE5). "Those were like my baby steps towards how long format works," he says. For *Kaala*, his second series of 2023, which released on September 15 on Disney+ Hotstar, he found himself performing the additional roles of showrunner, co-writer and producer. The volume of work, he says, took its toll. "But, eventually, it is all worth it," adds Nambiar.

Marking audio label and film producer T-Series' foray into web series, *Kaala* is on paper a thriller but one that has multiple tracks going on—there's a cat-and-mouse game between an Intelligence Bureau officer (Avinash Tiwary) and a businessman (Taher Shabbir) accused of money laundering; there's a father-son tale; there's an unresolved, traumatic event from the past whose tremors are still felt in the present; power games and there's action too. "When we were [initially] writing it, there was very little action planned," says Nambiar. "But, as we started developing it further, we saw pockets available where we would try to do [an action] set piece without it hampering the story."

For Nambiar, *Kaala* is essentially a show where there's more than what's on the surface. It's big on scale like *The Fame Game* (2022), but given the genre, there's plenty of spectacle too. "There are more layers to it," he adds. "It delves into many more aspects." The long-form storytelling in web series enables creators like Nambiar to do so with a wide range of characters and various subplots. The eight-episode series also features Rohan Vinod Mehra, Nivetha Pethuraj, Hiten Tejwani, Mini Mathur, Shruti Seth, among others, but the plot primarily pivots around three men who all have "darkness in each of them that manifests and creates havoc", he notes. If season one is received well, Nambiar already has a story in place to dig deeper into the *Kaala* world.



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As much as Nambiar has enjoyed his exploits on streaming, he is looking to get back to features. It's after all what put him on the map, with his debut *Shaitan* (2011) followed by *David* (2013) demonstrating a cinematic flair that saw him package his indie sensibilities into a commercial format. Nambiar adopts that formula again in his next, a Hindi-Tamil bilingual, also produced by T-Series, shot with two different sets of actors. Just don't ask him if his allegiance lies with films or series. His answer is diplomatic: "Wherever I get to showcase the best version of my story is where I will gravitate towards." ■

Suhani Singh